

**DIVINE SCENT**
Ladies sift the dried flowers at the S.V. Gosamrakshana Shala facility that makes incense sticks

## FRAGRANCE UNLIMITED

***TTD has cracked the recycling riddle with a range of value-added products***

Waste management follows a circular economy at the Tirumala Tirupati Devasthanams (TTD). Flower offerings to the deities at Tirumala and other temples are no longer dumped after they are spent. Since September 2021, the floral refuse is sent to an exclusive facility at the S.V. Gosamrakshana Shala in Tirupati where 80 workers turn it into high-quality, fragrant incense sticks. Some 1 million sticks are produced every day. From the mixing of ingredients to packaging, every process is done inhouse. "TTD wanted the downstream use of the flower waste to have a devotional connection and zeroed in on incense sticks," says T.S. Harsha, director, Darshan International, a major player in the incense stick industry. His company gifted a dehumidifier that dries the huge volumes of flowers without their losing their colour and intrinsic fragrance and provided the knowhow to make the sticks. With the growing demand, production of the seven fragrances—four perfumed and three flora varieties—are being doubled from October.

Floral waste can be put to many uses, from biodegradable packaging material to soaps and aromatic oils. It can also serve as raw material for handmade paper. TTD, in collaboration with the Dr YSR Horticulture University, Tirupati, has employed 180 women to make value-added products from it.

With the five panchagavvya derivatives from cows—cow dung, urine, milk, curd and ghee—widely used in Ayurveda, TTD has begun manufacturing these medicinal products under the brand name Namami Govinda. "Currently, we have 15 products and in a year it will go up to 50," says Dr Ram Kumar, director, Ashirwad Ayurveda Pharmacy Ltd. They are partnering with TTD's Sri Srinivasa Ayurveda Pharmacy and the SV Gosamrakshana Shala in manufacturing the products. Products worth Rs 1.23 crore have been sold since the launch on January 27.

Bengal gram farmers in the NF clusters of the state, trained them and now monitor the crop management. "Apart from handholding the farmers, we test the produce for pesticide residues before it is supplied to the TTD," explains T. Vijay Kumar, executive vice-chairperson, RySS (see *TTD's Organic Grocery List*).

Farmers are incentivised and assured a profit for the organic produce. TTD provides farmers a premium of 15 per cent over the market price. In the first year, farmers typically gained an average of Rs 10,000 extra per tonne. For 2022-23, RySS has identified 24,765 farmers from 4,953 SHGs to provide specified quantities of 12 NF commodities, including Bengal gram, red gram, black gram, jaggery, tamarind, rice, turmeric, black pepper, groundnut, green gram, coriander and mustard. The initiative is also a boost for the Andhra Pradesh Community Based Natural Farming (APCNF) programme started in 2015 (see *Fragrance Unlimited*).

Another facet of the RySS-TTD partnership is the supply of cows from the TTD *gaushala* to farmers supplying the NF produce. The bovines are provided free of cost, including transport. Already, 945 cows and 737 bulls have been sent to the Chittoor, Tirupati, YSR Kadapa, Anantapuram, Kurnool, Prakasam and Nellore districts. In addition, 92 bulls and 238 cows were distributed in the Nagarkurnool district of Telangana. The scheme will cover all the districts of Andhra Pradesh in the next two years under the aegis of the TTD's Gosamrakshana campaign. The TTD has also launched a Gudiko Gomatha programme, which will donate a cow and a calf to interested temples; 193 temples in five states have taken up the offer so far. ■